SkillNavora · Business AI Stack

COMPLETE GUIDE 01 OF 15

n8n Automation

A practical guide with steps, examples and a checklist. Read the chapter, then build the example.

AUTOMATION · COMPLETE GUIDE

n8n: workflow automation from first node to a Gmail AI agent

n8n is a workflow tool. Each step is a node, nodes are joined by lines, and data flows from left to right. This guide takes you from your first workflow to a complete example: an AI assistant that reads your Gmail, classifies each email, drafts replies, and tracks job applications in a sheet, with you approving every send.

1. What n8n is, and when to use it

- **Use n8n** when a task repeats (new lead, new email, new form response) and involves several apps.
- **Self-hosted or cloud.** You can run n8n on your own server, or use n8n Cloud. Your data stays where you host it.
- **Code when you need it.** Nodes cover most apps; a Code node (JavaScript or Python) handles the rest.

2. Core ideas

Term	Meaning
Workflow	A saved diagram of nodes. It runs when its trigger fires.
Trigger	The first node: a schedule, a webhook call, or a new item in an app (for example a new Gmail message).
Node	One step: send an email, call an API, transform data, ask an AI model.
Item	One record flowing through the workflow (one email, one row). Most nodes run once per item.
Expression	A value taken from an earlier node, written as `{{ $json.subject }}`.
Credential	The saved login for an app (Gmail, Sheets, OpenAI). Stored once, reused in many workflows.

3. Your first workflow in 10 minutes

1. Open n8n and choose **New workflow**. Click the **+** and add a **Schedule Trigger** set to every 1 minute, to test.
2. Add a **Set** node. Create a field `message` with the value `Hello from n8n at {{ $now }}`.
3. Click **Execute workflow** and open the output panel. You see one item with a `message` field. This is how you debug every workflow: run it, open each node, read the data.
4. Activate the workflow with the toggle. The schedule now runs on its own.

Test mode and production mode

A webhook has two addresses: a *test* URL that works only while you press Execute, and a *production* URL that works when the workflow is active. Use the test URL while building and the production URL in your live app.

4. Credentials: connect Gmail once, use everywhere

Gmail uses Google sign-in (OAuth). n8n asks Google for permission to read and send your mail. You do this once:

1. In the Google Cloud Console, create a project and enable the **Gmail API**.
2. Configure the **OAuth consent screen**: app name, your email, and add your own Gmail address as a **test user**.
3. Create an **OAuth client ID** of type *Web application*. Copy the **redirect URL** shown in n8n's Gmail credential screen into it.
4. Paste the client ID and client secret into n8n, click **Sign in with Google**, and approve the permissions. n8n now stores a refresh token; you do not paste your password anywhere.

PRIVACY RULE

Grant only the scopes you need: reading and sending mail, and labels. Never share a credential with a team member who does not need the mailbox. Keep the consent screen in test mode for personal use; Google's full review is needed for public apps.

5. Worked example: an AI assistant for your Gmail and job applications

We build two workflows. Workflow A handles incoming mail. Workflow B tracks and prepares job applications. Both keep you in control: nothing is sent to a new contact until you approve it.

Workflow A: classify, draft, and label incoming email

#	Node	What it does
1	Gmail Trigger	Polls new messages in your inbox every minute (filter: unread, label INBOX).
2	Set	Keeps only the fields you need: `from`, `subject`, `snippet` (short text), `id`.
3	OpenAI or Claude node (Message a model)	Classifies the email into `job_reply`, `recruiter_outreach`, `invoice`, `newsletter` or `other`, and returns JSON only.
4	Switch	Routes each item by its class.
5	OpenAI or Claude node (drafting)	For recruiter and job replies only: drafts a reply in your voice, using a short profile you keep in a Set node or sheet.
6	Gmail node: Create Draft	Saves the draft as a reply in the same thread. It is not sent.
7	Gmail node: Add Label	Adds the label `AI-drafted` so you can find them.
8	Telegram or WhatsApp node (optional)	Sends you a one-line summary: "Draft ready for Priya at Acme: interview request."

The classification prompt is short and strict:

```
You classify one email. Return only JSON: {"class": "...", "reason": "..."}.
Allowed classes: job_reply, recruiter_outreach, invoice, newsletter, other.
Email from: {{ $json.from }}
Subject: {{ $json.subject }}
Snippet: {{ $json.snippet }}
```

The drafting prompt adds your profile and the rule that the reply must not promise anything you have not confirmed:

```
Write a reply of at most 120 words in a warm, direct tone. Use only the facts in PROFILE.
Do not commit to salary, dates or availability; ask for them instead.
PROFILE: {{ $json.profile }}
EMAIL: {{ $json.snippet }}
```

Workflow B: a job application tracker that prepares, and waits for approval

1. Create a Google Sheet `Job applications` with columns: `role`, `company`, `job_link`, `recruiter_email`, `status` (to tailor, ready, approved, sent), `tailored_note`, `sent_at`.
2. Schedule Trigger every hour → Google Sheets node (Get rows where `status = to tailor`).
3. For each row, a model node writes a 100-word cover note from your profile and the job description you pasted in. It must quote only facts from your profile.
4. Google Sheets node (Update row): sets `tailored_note` and `status = ready`. You read it, and change `status` to `approved` when happy.
5. A second scheduled workflow picks up rows with `status = approved`, sends the email with your CV attached through the Gmail node, then sets `status = sent` and `sent_at`.

WHERE AUTOMATION IS ALLOWED
Email applications to a recruiter's published address, and applications through a company's official form or a documented API, are normal. Do not automate submissions on job portals whose terms prohibit bots, and do not scrape sites. Always keep the approval step for anything sent to a person.

6. Testing and going live

- Test with your own second email address first. Check the draft, the label, and the sheet.
- Use a small batch: 5 emails per run, then increase.
- Add an error workflow: when a node fails, n8n sends you an alert.
- Log every decision (class, reason, time) in a sheet, so you can review mistakes.

7. Common mistakes

- No approval step, so the AI sends something you did not see.

- Trusting the model's JSON without checking it. Add an IF node that rejects anything outside the allowed classes.
- Sharing your whole inbox with a prompt. Send only the subject and a short snippet.
- Forgetting the test versus production webhook URL.

8. Checklist

- Credentials created once; scopes limited.
- Test address used; approvals in place.
- Error alerts on; logs in a sheet.
- Prompts stored in one place; no secrets inside prompts.

Check interface names and node versions against the n8n documentation (docs.n8n.io) before you build; n8n updates nodes often.